Chapter Three

The Arab League

"If I were an Arab leader, I would never sign an agreement with Israel."

—David Ben-Gurion

The Arab League (formally the League of Arab States) was created in Cairo in 1945. Initially, it had six members: Egypt, Syria, Saudi Arabia, Iraq, Jordan, and Lebanon, but other Arab nations soon joined. The purpose of the League was to provide a forum for the discussion of issues affecting all Arab nations, including trade and other matters relating to the sovereignty of its members. However, it soon came to focus on a single issue: the creation of a Jewish homeland in Palestine.

Most of the members of the League supported the notion of the establishment of the nation of Palestine, but all were bitterly opposed to the partition suggested first by the British in 1936 and then by the United Nations in 1947. Many had hoped that the ALA would prove able to overcome the forces of Haganah, but when the ALA was defeated in the only major battle it fought during the civil war, at the kibbutz of Mishmar HaEmek, it became clear that this wouldn't happen. As a result, the League established a military committee under the leadership of a retired Iraqi general, Isma'il Safwat.

The purpose of the committee was to assess whether support from other Arab nations might allow Palestinians to successfully fight the Israelis. Safwat's conclusion was that this was very unlikely and that the only way to avoid the establishment of a permanent Jewish state in the Middle East was direct military intervention by neighboring Arab countries. Initially, the League ignored this advice, but by April 1948, it was clear that no group within Mandatory Palestine could prevent the creation of Israel. At that point, the members of the League made a decision that they would invade the